Rldcoin: Interstellar Peer-to-Peer Payments

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Abstract. A community separated from another by years of communication delay needs money whose local history does not depend on a later contest with distant computation. We propose a payment architecture in which each spendable output has one authoritative home domain. A domain finalizes local transfers under an explicitly accepted Byzantine fault model. To pay another domain, the owner first removes value from local spendability and obtains a recipient-bound export certificate. The destination verifies that certificate and atomically records either one import or one permanent rejection. An import creates local spending authority; a rejection can authorize recovery at the source. Silence authorizes neither. This separation permits one-way delivery, independent local payments during interstellar disconnection, and onward spending without a return message. We give the state transitions, a conservation argument over causal histories, and the conditions under which unrelated reconnection cannot reverse a local payment. The cost is explicit: users must accept the security of the domains in their funds' provenance, a failed quorum can stop its domain, and an unreachable destination can strand exported value. The architecture combines local settlement and asynchronous authority transfer without a global transaction order, compulsory central relay, or mandatory new token. It makes a specific claim about conserved payment under stated trust assumptions, not an unconditional claim about future adoption, physical delivery or cryptographic permanence.

1. A payment system for separated worlds

Consider two settlements that can communicate only through messages taking years to arrive. People at either settlement still need to pay wages, buy food and transfer savings. Requiring both settlements to approve each purchase would make their communication delay the minimum payment time. Letting both independently spend the same funds would create a different problem: the system could deliver two apparently valid claims against one value.

A single greatest-work history resolves competing branches by eventually discarding one. That is useful under its network and adversary assumptions [1], but it is a poor basis for the promise that an isolated settlement's years of ordinary commerce will remain part of its monetary history. Even honest communities can grow incompatible branches while contact is absent. More local confirmations do not reveal an unseen remote history.

We instead locate the authority to resolve each spend conflict before allowing the spend. Value usable in domain A is not simultaneously usable in domain B. Within A, the local settlement protocol decides whether an owner has spent an output. A payment to B first makes the output unusable in A, then carries evidence allowing B to exercise the transferred authority once. A transport receipt is not sufficient; a certified monetary transition is required.

This is an allocation of authority, not a way around propagation delay. Local payment can finish without a distant message because its inputs already have a local home. Newly transferred authority still needs a real sequence of contacts to reach its destination. A community that wants independent operation must place its funds and sufficient validation capacity there before losing contact.

The intended benefit is durable economic separation: losing a route to another world need not erase an already settled local wage or require a distant institution to approve tomorrow's purchase. The same mechanism is relevant to remote communities, disrupted infrastructure and intermittently connected vehicles. Its usefulness depends on the security and availability assumptions below, rather than on geographical labels.

2. Model, identities and assumptions

A domain is a replicated state machine with a stable identity D, an authenticated initial descriptor and a sequence of certified configurations. It need not coincide with a planet. Two nearby communities may use different domains, while a badly chosen domain spanning a stellar gap would inherit that gap's local confirmation delay. Domain creation is open; acceptance of a domain's certificates is an explicit user and receiving-domain decision.

The baseline domain has n = 3f + 1 distinct validators and a finalization rule requiring a protocol-specific commit proof from at least 2f + 1 validators. It uses an established Byzantine state-machine-replication protocol with its locking and view-change rules, such as the family represented by PBFT and HotStuff [2,3]. A list of signatures on an arbitrary state root is not a replacement for that protocol's commit proof. Honest validators execute every state transition, preserve durable consensus locks and do not finalize conflicting states at the same position.

Safety assumes no more than f Byzantine validators in each relevant configuration, unforgeable authorization and certificate signatures, collision-resistant commitments, correct verification, and recovery that does not erase committed state or import decisions. Liveness additionally requires a responsive local quorum, eventual local communication conditions sufficient for the selected consensus protocol, fair admission and adequate resources. Safety does not require a timely interstellar return path. Eventual delivery does require an eventual usable forward path.

Owners control spending keys independently of validators and relays. An adversary may copy an owner's key, submit conflicting authorizations, control carriers, duplicate or reorder messages, delay traffic indefinitely, and advertise false routes. It cannot exceed a stated validator fault threshold or break a cryptographic assumption within a claim that relies on that assumption. A threshold compromise is a security failure, not a recoverable network delay.

A client authenticates an initial domain descriptor through a separately accepted trust anchor. A peer advertisement, hostname or self-signed new descriptor cannot establish that anchor. The descriptor commits to the protocol and asset rules, validator identities, signature and hash suites, epoch-transition rule, fee policy and finite resource limits. Distinct identities do not establish independent operators. Admission and validator replacement are governance and Sybil-resistance decisions; the payment protocol does not turn arbitrary public keys into trusted validators.

The claims concern digital ledger rights. Physical redemption, exchange rates and the honesty of an external asset issuer are additional assumptions. Nothing in a certificate proves that a warehouse contains goods or that a bank holds a corresponding deposit.

3. Money with one authoritative home

An asset descriptor identifies its denomination, authorized genesis balances or issuance rule, retirement rule and issuance authority. Its digest is the asset identifier. Distinct issuers or different issuance rules create distinct assets even when they use the same symbol. Rldcoin is a payment protocol: it does not require a newly sold token, a particular supply cap, proof of work, a founder allocation or an automatic reward for creating a domain.

For a closed fixed-supply asset, let M be the sum of its authenticated initial balances. The asset descriptor binds each initial allocation to an exact output identifier, amount and home domain; creating another domain cannot replay that allocation. New domains start with zero balance in that asset; they obtain value through valid transfers. For an issuing asset, M changes only through an explicitly authorized issuance or retirement transition under that asset's descriptor. Importing an export never counts as issuance. A federation that wants fixed scarcity must select a fixed-supply descriptor or a fully specified bounded issuance policy; naming an asset does not establish scarcity or fair distribution.

A spendable output records its identifier, asset, integer amount, owner authorization policy, home domain and provenance set. Only the home domain can consume it. A local transfer consumes unspent inputs and produces new outputs, with any fee represented as an ordinary output to the domain's declared service rule. Every required actual input owner authorizes the complete operation. Inputs must share one asset and one home; cross-domain multi-input atomic purchases are outside the basic transfer operation.

```
LocalTransfer:
  consume existing, authorized, unspent local inputs
  create recipient, change and service-fee outputs
  require sum(inputs) = sum(outputs)
```

Geographical movement of a key does not move its output's home. A traveler who takes only a key into an isolated ship cannot spend an Earth-homed output there without contacting Earth's authority. The traveler must relocate authority before departure or accept a ship's separately offered credit. Credit is a distinct liability, never a silently duplicated balance.

The basic state contains an unspent-output map U, a source export map E, a destination decision map J, an authenticated configuration history and resource/fee rules. At a destination, J[x] is initially absent and can become Imported or Rejected. At a source, E[x] records Exported and can later record Refunded following authenticated rejection. Receipts may annotate an export as delivered, but do not restore local spending authority.

4. Local settlement and its meaning

An owner signs the exact asset and domain identities, operation type, input references, ordered output policies and amounts, explicit fees, and a nonce or input-derived uniqueness commitment. Distinct action tags separate a local transfer, export, rejection request and recovery. Canonical encoding distinguishes field types, lengths and integer values. Hashes and signatures bind the complete object, including protocol and cryptographic-suite versions. The baseline can use established ordinary signatures such as Ed25519 [4]; its long-term compromise implications are considered in Section 13.

A node first verifies the owner authorization, input availability, amounts, provenance and admission conditions. The local consensus engine orders competing uses of an input and finalizes the resulting state. A client reports a locally settled payment only after checking the commit evidence and its exact output inclusion, and retaining recoverable receipt material. A submission acknowledgment or a preliminary quorum vote is not settlement.

A recipient can consume a settled output in the next local state transition. No separate global block, mining reward maturity or stellar acknowledgment is required. Connected participants can therefore make low-latency payments directly on their local final ledger. The design does not need an illustrative payment channel to explain ordinary local use.

This finality is conditional on the domain and provenance fault assumptions. It means that valid future protocol execution does not reorganize an already finalized local prefix. It does not mean that validators cannot censor, that keys cannot be stolen, that software cannot fail, or that a compromised quorum has a cryptographic obligation to repair losses. A damaged domain has an incident requiring explicit recovery and acceptance decisions; a distant branch is never automatically chosen to overwrite its history.

During a partition within one domain, only a component able to satisfy the same quorum and locking rules can continue. Minority components wait. Two components do not gain independent access to the same outputs by declaring themselves surviving communities. If a community needs its own payment availability, it must establish a separate domain and relocate its funds while the old authority is still available.

5. Export: surrender before sending

Before payment, a recipient can publish a signed payment request containing its asset, destination domain identity, owner key or authorization policy, principal and acceptance conditions. The payer authenticates these fields. A copied place name, a new relay address or an unsolicited key is not an authenticated invoice. An invoice can guide admission, but it cannot give a relay authority to replace the destination or change a released payment.

The payer constructs a ticket T naming the source A, destination B, exact recipient, asset, principal v, source fee f_A, destination import fee f_B, recovery owner, recovery fee r, source inputs, owner nonce and provenance commitment. The stable domain identities bind authenticated initial descriptors; the source must support the destination rejection-verification rule before accepting an export that offers recovery. The destination service-fee rule and the

recovery rule are also bound. The exported amount is a = v + f_B. Source inputs cover a + f_A and any explicit change. A ticket has no elapsed-time rule that restores its value at A.

```
x = H("export", protocol, asset, A, B, canonical(T))
a = v + f_B
require v > 0, 0 <= r <= a, and bounded nonnegative amounts
require all input owners sign T and its exact change
require no input is already spent or exported
```

Export is one atomic source transition. It consumes the inputs, creates source change and the authorized source service fee, and inserts E[x] = Exported(T, a). The amount a is no longer spendable at A. The finalized export record is committed into the source state and accompanied by its inclusion proof and the source consensus commit evidence. The owner signature alone is not an export certificate.

Certificate release follows durable local finalization. A crash before finalization supplies no transfer authority. A crash after finalization must recover the same export, rather than refunding it or authorizing an alternative spend. Wallet intent and exact bytes are retained before submission so that a lost response can be reconciled against certified state. A local reservation before export is useful wallet bookkeeping; the committed export is the monetary lock.

The payer can cancel an unfinalized proposal only through the source's ordinary conflict-resolution rules. Once exported, no source timeout, sender absence, carrier acknowledgment or local administrator can make a spendable replacement. This constraint is necessary because a valid copy may already be traveling toward B.

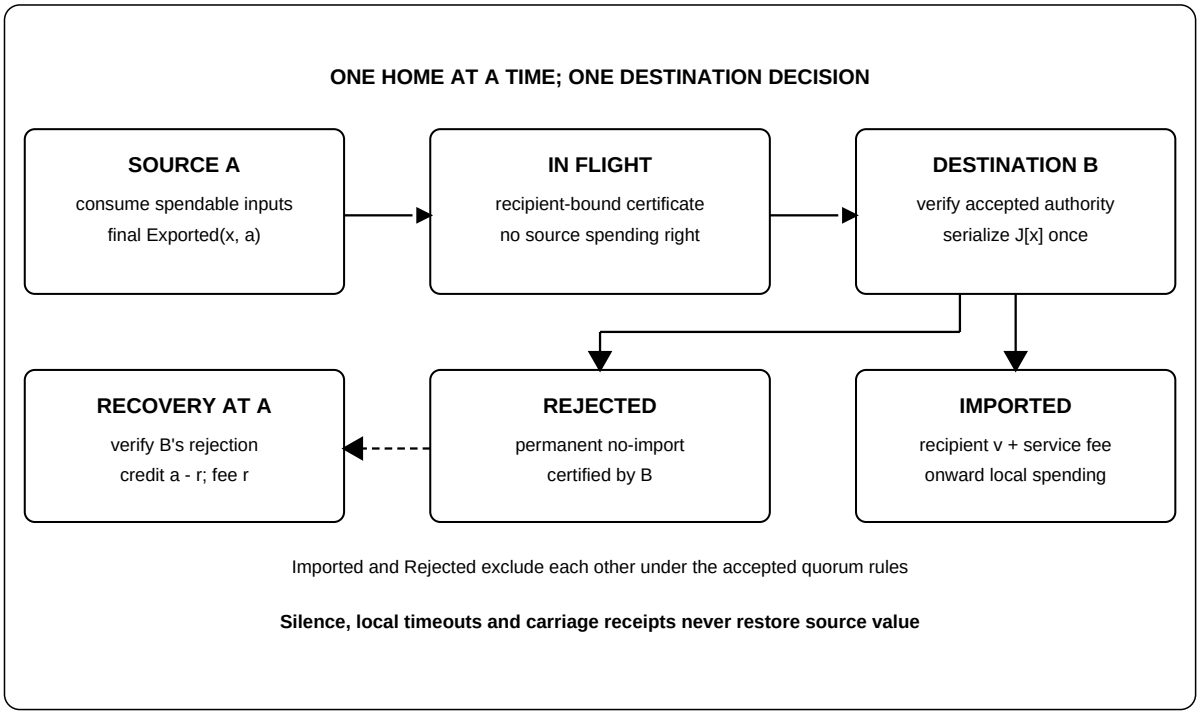

Figure 1. One exported amount can become one destination credit or one source recovery. The destination's permanent decision excludes the other outcome; a transport receipt grants neither.

6. Import: a single destination decision

The forward package contains T and its owner authorizations, source export inclusion proof, complete commit evidence, and the source configuration chain needed to reach an accepted trust anchor. The destination checks the exact asset and domain identities, all bound amounts and policies, the source commit semantics and proof membership, and its own provenance and resource admission rules. An arbitrary source root or a relayer's attestation cannot initialize a trusted remote state.

The baseline verifies certified source execution under the accepted source-validator assumption. It does not claim that a Merkle path independently proves all historical transaction validity. A validity-proof alternative would add a particular proof system and data-availability assumptions; it is not silently supplied by the word certificate. Established interoperability protocols similarly distinguish remote consensus verification from transporting messages [5].

Any party may submit a complete authentic package to B; neither the payer nor recipient must be online to sign again. B processes a valid package through its own consensus. The atomic import transition requires J[x] to be absent, sets J[x] = Imported(H(T)), and creates the exact principal v for the named recipient plus f_B for the bound destination service rule. The output's home is B. These effects finalize together; a crash cannot durably credit the recipient without also consuming the ticket identity, or consume it while losing a finalized output.

```
Import(T, source_commit):
  require authentic final Exported(T, a) at source A
  require T.destination = this stable domain B
  require J[x] is absent
  require current destination admission accepts T
  atomically:
    J[x] = Imported(H(T))
    U += recipient(v), destination_service(f_B)
```

An exact duplicate returns or reconstructs the existing result without creating value. A different ticket under the same identifier, a ticket addressed to another domain, or an object with mixed proof fragments is rejected. The decision namespace uses the full currency/protocol/domain binding, not a transport message number. Source and destination identifiers remain stable through authorized key changes, so switching epochs does not create a fresh import namespace.

After destination finalization, the recipient may spend locally or export onward. A return message to A can report the import and improve the payer's information, but is not a condition of B's credit or the recipient's next payment. If A is later unreachable, an already obtained authentic export can still be imported provided B retains a valid source trust chain and all security assumptions remain applicable.

A relay may carry A-to-B evidence through C without C becoming a monetary intermediary. Conversely, importing into C and then exporting to B is a distinct monetary route with additional fees and trust dependencies. Physical route selection cannot silently substitute the latter for the former.

7. Rejection, cancellation and stranded value

A source cannot distinguish a lost message from an imported payment whose receipt was lost. Restoring the source balance in both cases would duplicate value in the second case. The basic protocol therefore has no automatic elapsed-time refund. Transport expiry, an invoice deadline and a local user-interface timeout can stop a delivery attempt; none reverses E[x].

Recovery requires positive destination evidence. A payer-authorized rejection request carries the authentic export and the recovery-owner authorization bound by T. The recipient may also authorize rejection. The destination verifies the same source identity and export evidence used for import, and serializes rejection against import in J. If J[x] is absent, it may atomically set J[x] = Rejected(H(T)). If already Imported, it cannot issue a valid rejection. A repeated Rejected decision returns the same outcome. Any destination operation fee for requesting rejection is separately funded under its local admission rules.

Rejected is a permanent monetary decision, not a temporary delivery error. It forbids every later import of x, including after restart, state compaction and validator replacement. A malformed package, full queue or unrecognized source yields a refusal or Pending status, not a usable rejection certificate. To certify rejection, B must accept enough of the ticket's authenticated identity and configuration rules to bind a permanent decision. This requirement prevents a source from treating an unauthenticated error as a refund.

```
Recover(T, destination_rejection):
  require authentic final J[x] = Rejected(H(T)) at B
  require E[x] is exactly Exported(T, a), not Refunded
  require T's bound recovery rule permits amount a - r
  atomically:
    E[x] = Refunded(H(T))
    U += recovery_owner(a - r), source_service(r)
```

The source authenticates the destination decision through the destination's accepted initial descriptor and configuration chain, not through keys supplied as an unverified field in the rejection. A replay cannot recover twice. If policy or fee changes make processing unavailable, the operation waits or uses a separately authorized sponsor; the protocol does not alter the recipient, principal or refund formula to force progress.

Import and rejection requests can race. Their order at B determines which terminal decision exists. A payer's request is not a guaranteed recall, and a source export is not yet destination settlement. Once imported, reversal requires a new payment authorized by the current recipient. Rerouting an unimported ticket requires certified rejection and recovery followed by a new owner-authorized export; the carrier cannot edit T.

If B is permanently destroyed or cannot assemble its required quorum, the source may never obtain either import or rejection evidence. The value remains in flight and unavailable at A. This is the explicit availability cost of preserving exclusivity without remote communication. Insurance, credit and negotiated compensation may address the economic loss through separately funded arrangements. They do not change the original ticket's state or create a second claim by declaration.

8. An interstellar payment and local autonomy

Alice in domain A pays Bob in domain B. Alice verifies Bob's request, authorizes T, and waits for A's final export certificate. A removes the exported amount from its usable balance set. Alice gives complete copies to willing carriers and may go offline. Bob may be offline while those copies cross successive one-way contacts.

When the package arrives, B checks the accepted source authority and exact ticket, then finalizes its one import decision. Bob obtains a normal local output. He can pay Carol in B under B's local quorum without querying Alice or A. He can also authorize an export to a third domain, which repeats the same surrender-and-import mechanism. Bob's receipt back to Alice can follow another route years later without holding up these local payments.

```
A: Alice's spendable funds -> final export x
Physical contacts: copy and carry x plus complete evidence
B: undecided x -> final Imported(x) -> Bob's local output
B: Bob -> Carol through ordinary local settlement
Optional return: evidence of import, with no source re-credit
```

Disconnection from A cannot, by itself, reverse B's finalized payments. There is no global competition in which A's greater work replaces B's history. That property follows from preassigned conflict authority and local finality, and remains conditional on the integrity of the authorities in the funds' provenance. Reconnection brings new payments, receipts and incident evidence; it does not add two versions of a balance together.

Two disconnected domains can both continue using their distinct local funds. A partition inside B cannot create two B quorums with independent copies of those funds under the fault assumption. A ship wanting autonomous payments therefore needs its own accepted domain and transferred balances before departure. Merely running another copy of B's software does not supply a new authority or a new balance.

A ship with one validator is a domain only under a zero-validator-fault assumption. It has no Byzantine replication tolerance and depends on that validator's durable state and availability. The architecture does not label one surviving machine as equivalent to an independent fault-tolerant community. Safety-preserving emergency replacement requires the existing authorized handoff rule; inability to meet that rule can mean a permanent halt.

9. Provenance and the spread of trust

Cross-domain finality is conditional, not trust-free. If an accepted source quorum can certify fictitious exports or conflicting histories, signatures on those statements do not make the value real. A destination cannot learn an undisclosed remote compromise from the absence of an alarm. Waiting for a fixed local interval does not solve an unbounded stellar communication delay.

Each output therefore carries an authenticated provenance set P of authority descriptors and configuration histories on which its backing has depended. Genesis or issuance creates the initial set. A local transfer propagates the union of its inputs' sets. Export binds that union plus its source authority; import adds the destination authority. A recovered output and its recovery-fee output retain the original provenance and add both the source and the destination configurations that authorized rejection and recovery. Source change and source fees retain their input provenance plus the executing source authority. Combining outputs never removes an authority from their provenance. Authorized validator succession extends the relevant configuration history rather than erasing its old fault assumptions.

A receiving policy specifies which assets, authorities and configurations it accepts. Before spending or accepting, the user can inspect the resulting set. Value routed through a reputable domain does not automatically acquire that domain's trust alone. If A-imported value is passed through B, B must preserve A's provenance. Ordinary transport through a carrier adds no monetary authority; monetary import into that carrier's domain does.

This rule is enforced by honest domain validators and their authenticated state transitions. It is not a zero-knowledge proof that no hidden compromised authority ever existed. A malicious quorum that exceeds the assumed fault bound can lie about state and provenance; that is outside the conservation claim. Signatures locate responsibility and can expose equivocation once evidence meets, but do not recover missing backing or guarantee a market value.

Two balances with the same denomination and different provenance can have different acceptance and exchange value. A wallet must not merge them into an apparently risk-free total. Limits on accepted principal or outstanding tickets can bound a particular wallet's declared exposure at admission, but do not bound losses across an arbitrary economy. Repeated circulation and contingent liabilities require a separate risk model. No global loss cap is inferred from a per-peer quota.

Explicit provenance makes an uncomfortable tradeoff visible: an open network can let anyone create and advertise a domain, while recipients retain the right to refuse its monetary authority. Universal automatic acceptance of arbitrary new validators would require an additional Sybil-resistant security construction. This paper does not disguise that missing assumption as permissionless consensus.

10. Transport and durable evidence

Relays provide store-carry-forward service across actual contacts [6]. The transport envelope identifies its version, exact content hash and length, origin authentication and destination domain. A fragmented object binds all piece positions to the same whole commitment. The receiver reconstructs and authenticates the complete object before monetary processing. Duplicate copies, parallel routes and repeated custody acknowledgments never create a second ticket decision.

An admitted custodian durably stores the agreed complete bytes before acknowledging custody. A digest without the material is not retained evidence. Capacity refusal occurs before accepting a new obligation; an existing custody contract specifies retention and failure reporting. Replication across independent carriers can reduce exposure to a lost copy, but correlated loss and fraudulent storage claims remain possible. A signed receipt proves a signed custody assertion, not future storage, delivery or payment finality.

End-to-end authentication survives relay changes; contact authentication protects the particular link [7]. A two-way link may negotiate missing dependencies. A one-way transfer carries its complete required export and authority material, or arranges for the missing material to arrive by another route. Sender and recipient need not be simultaneously online. Discovery helps locate candidate contacts, while a bootstrap still needs authentic rules and a first real contact or carried archive.

For distance d, propagation speed at most c implies that new information cannot arrive before d/c. Actual settlement also includes contact waiting, serialization, proof verification and destination consensus. Where a path and the necessary trust material already exist, ordinary import has no protocol-mandated interstellar round trip. Recovery after rejection requires destination evidence to travel back to the source and consequently has a different latency.

Forwarding schedules, physical media, energy and carrier motion are outside monetary consensus. A route advertisement cannot promote a new domain descriptor to a trust anchor or change T's destination. The absence of a universal Earth directory removes one service dependency; it does not create an unavailable physical route or guarantee that a carrier will accept the job.

11. Fees, liquidity and incentives

Local service fees are explicit owner-authorized transfers to the payout rule committed by the domain. They pay for validation, bandwidth, durable state and administration under that domain's economic policy. There is no reward for merely generating identities or duplicating packets. An issuer may choose a separate issuance-funded security budget, but the payment protocol does not invent one. A low or zero fee policy needs some other declared funding source.

A successful cross-domain payment moves a + f_A out of the payer's inputs: f_A goes to source service, while a = v + f_B becomes an exported right. Import creates v for the recipient and f_B for destination service. Rejection leaves a unavailable until recovery, which creates a - r for the recovery owner and r for source service. These exact amounts and rules are authorized in T. A change in future operating costs may require a sponsor or cause delay; it cannot silently take additional principal.

Relaying is a separate purchased service. A carrier can quote a fee for a finite custody and forwarding contract, paid locally or through separately authorized tickets. Prepayment exposes the customer to carrier failure; payment after proof of delivery exposes the carrier to delay and evidence availability. A custody receipt alone does not settle this fair-exchange problem. Honest service providers need funded contracts, reputation, collateral or legal arrangements appropriate to their risk; none is assumed free or automatically supplied by validator fees.

Transferred authority has a capital cost. If exports depart at rate lambda units per unit time and their average unavailable interval is W, an average in-flight inventory of approximately lambda*W follows under stable-flow conditions, applying the flow relation associated with Little's law [14] to units of value. Long contact gaps can therefore tie up substantial value even if each certificate is small. Prepositioning funds, reciprocal trade and liquidity providers can improve local usability, but credit and exchange introduce their own pricing, collateral and counterparty assumptions.

The basic mechanism transfers one asset. Simultaneous exchange of independent assets or delivery of physical goods is not automatically atomic across stellar delay. A provider promising immediate destination liquidity is making an additional economic arrangement; it must not present that credit as a completed import of a ticket that has not arrived.

12. Conservation and safety argument

Fix an asset and a causally consistent cut of the execution: every included destination action includes its causal source export. Let U be the total spendable value, including service-fee outputs, across all domains at that cut. Let F be the principal plus reserved destination fees in exports that have not yet been imported or recovered. A permanently rejected ticket remains in F until source recovery; a copied packet contributes nothing separately. Let I be authorized cumulative issuance, G initial supply and Z cumulative retirement. The invariant is:

```
U + F = G + I - Z
```

F is a mathematical accounting category over the actual causal execution, not a total that a disconnected source can infer from missing receipts. After an import, a stale source may still display Exported, but its entry is not an additional spendable allocation. A domain's observable balances, pending exports and receipts must remain separate from any claim to a live global balance.

Lemma 1: one local decision. Two quorums of size 2f + 1 among 3f + 1 validators intersect in at least f + 1 validators. With at most f Byzantine, the intersection contains an honest validator. The selected consensus protocol's durable locking

and commit rules prevent honest validators from participating in conflicting finalized state transitions. Quorum arithmetic alone is insufficient without those rules and valid reconfiguration. Thus, under the local safety assumptions, one input cannot be finalized into conflicting spends and J[x] cannot finalize as both Imported and Rejected.

Lemma 2: one destination. The owner authorization and source certificate bind the stable destination identity into T and x. An import transition checks that identity. Other domains cannot use the same certificate to credit themselves under the protocol. Duplicate delivery within B encounters the same permanent J[x]. The result holds across restarts and authorized epochs only if the decision map and its authenticated continuity are retained.

Lemma 3: import excludes recovery. Recovery requires a final Rejected decision from B. By Lemma 1 that decision excludes Imported; by Lemma 2 no other domain can import the same ticket. Source recovery additionally changes the exact E[x] once to Refunded. Therefore a ticket cannot produce both destination spendability and source recovery under the relevant source and destination fault assumptions. A conflicting signed import and rejection is evidence that an assumption failed, not a rule for choosing both.

Proposition: conservation. Initial state satisfies the invariant by the asset's authenticated allocation. A local transfer preserves U. Export decreases U by a and increases F by a; source fees only redistribute U. Import decreases F by a and increases U by v + f_B = a. Rejection changes neither U nor F. Recovery decreases F by a and increases U by (a - r) + r = a. Valid issuance and retirement change the right-hand side by the same amount as spendable or in-flight rights. Lemmas 1-3 exclude a second application of any value-creating branch. Induction over the causal execution therefore preserves the equation.

Proposition: isolation does not reorganize local settlement. A domain's valid next state extends its own finalized prefix. Import consumes a certificate; it does not replace that prefix with a remote branch. Consequently, loss or restoration of an inter-domain connection cannot by itself invalidate an already finalized local output. This is a conditional local-finality property, not a proof that a compromised provenance authority or stolen owner key cannot cause loss.

Conditional progress. Suppose the source has finalized an export, the required complete evidence eventually reaches the destination, its admission policy accepts the ticket, its correct local quorum makes progress and no authorized rejection is finalized first. Fair processing then finalizes import without any source return message. If rejection is finalized instead, complete rejection evidence eventually reaches the source and its correct quorum and bound recovery policy remain available, fair processing can finalize recovery once. Permanent disconnection, an unavailable quorum, expired cryptographic confidence or unfunded service invalidates the relevant progress premise; no universal deadline follows.

These arguments establish properties of the stated transition system and assumptions. They are not a machine-checked implementation proof, a proof of a new consensus algorithm, or a guarantee that arbitrary combinations of asset policies are safe. In particular, a source threshold compromise, lost anti-replay state, unverified configuration change or broken signature invalidates the applicable premise.

13. Configuration, keys and long journeys

A domain descriptor commits to a validator-succession rule. A conservative transition finalizes a handoff containing the old and new configurations, activation position, exact predecessor, complete monetary-state commitment and import/export decision roots. It requires an old-configuration commit proof and acceptance by a new quorum. Old validators stop authorizing the old configuration beyond that boundary; new validators install and durably retain the complete state before voting. A client follows this authenticated chain from its accepted anchor. An administrator-supplied replacement root is not a valid handoff.

A handoff must preserve every unresolved export, every Imported or Rejected decision, owner outputs and provenance. Merely copying current balances is insufficient. If an old quorum cannot authorize succession, the baseline cannot safely declare a replacement committee and resume the same funds. A newly formed community can establish a new identity, but it cannot acquire the stopped domain's balance by naming itself its successor.

Ordinary signatures remain forgeable if the relevant old private keys are later compromised. Rotating public keys does not retroactively prevent a forged historical certificate. The baseline safety model therefore counts later compromise of an old signing quorum against that configuration's fault assumption. A stronger long-journey profile needs an explicitly instantiated forward-secure or key-evolving signature construction [13], secure erasure and independent historical anchors; none follows automatically from regular key rotation.

A traveler pins the authenticated epoch material needed for an expected journey and its stated security horizon. Long delays make revocation inherently late. A newly arrived warning can justify refusing further acceptance, but does not produce an instantaneous worldwide revocation or a funded reimbursement. Unknown suites and unsupported transitions are rejected. Post-quantum standards can inform future profiles [8]; adopting one requires exact historical verification and renewal rules, not merely a new algorithm name.

Owner recovery is likewise an authorization policy selected before loss, such as a threshold of independently held recovery keys. Changing owners through that policy requires an ordinary certified local transition. No relay, founder or unauthenticated backup can reset an owner or recover an in-flight ticket. An old backup must reconstruct current certified state and current decisions before new signing or voting. If every recoverable copy and freshness anchor is lost, the protocol cannot manufacture the missing state.

The transparent baseline reveals amounts, public keys, provenance and some timing and route information. Encryption of carriage protects its declared audience, not all metadata. Private-payment constructions such as Zef address a different part of this problem [9]; integrating privacy would require its own proof that hidden amounts, provenance policy and duplicate prevention still compose.

14. Capacity, archives and failure bounds

Local throughput depends on validator count, execution cost, signature checks, replication, durable storage and local communication. Interstellar import adds certificate and configuration verification. Let domains i sustain completed local-payment rates r_i under declared conditions. Aggregate rate is at most the sum of those capacities after imports, exports, fees and configuration work consume their shares. That aggregate says nothing about the latency of a particular stellar route.

For a workload of one hundred million distinct payments per day, average completion rate is approximately 1157.41 per second. As arithmetic only, 64 independent domains each sustaining 25 payments per second would supply 1600 per second before overhead. This is neither a benchmark nor a guarantee that a particular quorum, device, asset or traffic distribution reaches those rates. A highly concentrated destination remains a bottleneck. Spreading one shared balance over domains requires actual authority relocation; it is not free horizontal replication.

Permanent duplicate prevention has a permanent state cost. An authenticated map can compress a decision set into a small root for certificates, but validators still need the map data or authenticated witnesses sufficient to update it correctly. Deleting an old rejection because a ticket seems unlikely to arrive reopens the import/recovery race. Deleting an old import similarly enables duplicate credit. Snapshot renewal preserves these facts rather than declaring old packets harmless by age.

For scale intuition, 100 million new decisions daily at 64 bytes per retained entry would add about 2.34 terabytes per year before indexes, replicas and archive redundancy. A 1000-byte record per payment would represent 100 gigabytes per day before certificate overhead and replication. Domains need explicit capacity, retention funding, backup verification and recovery plans. Roots do not eliminate these resources, and these figures do not establish a concrete encoding size.

A source can snapshot finalized exports and a destination can snapshot its decision map under its authenticated local finality. New validators verify the snapshot commitment, succession and required data availability before continuing. Pruning redundant historical payloads is possible only when every needed authorization, decision and recovery witness remains recoverable under a precisely defined archive policy. A proposed accumulator or succinct proof needs its own update, soundness, availability and recovery analysis.

If a quorum, archive or accepted cryptographic profile fails, affected progress stops. Discovery and carriers may continue forwarding preserved material, but they cannot vote, issue a replacement balance or convert a storage acknowledgment into an import. Bounded admission can refuse new obligations while retaining old ones. A promise of unlimited operation on finite ordinary hardware would contradict these obligations.

15. Relation to prior work and scope of the contribution

Bitcoin established a practical open-work approach to selecting a monetary history [1]. Byzantine state-machine replication supplies conditional finality for explicitly admitted validators [2,3]. This proposal chooses the latter inside a domain to avoid making distant work competition the arbiter of an isolated community's completed transactions. That choice changes the trust and availability model; it is not an improvement in every dimension.

FastPay and Zef show that payment workloads need not pay the cost of one global total order and describe concrete authority-based payment systems [9,10]. Research on asynchronous asset transfer likewise separates transfer requirements from general consensus [11]. These results motivate locality and careful conflict scopes. Their security assumptions and measured results do not automatically transfer to this architecture.

IBC separates remote-consensus verification, packet transport and application transitions [5]. Cross-shard research studies atomic commit and the dangers of replay, stale messages and client-coordinated locks [12]. Surrendering source spendability and consuming a unique destination identifier belong to that established family of ideas. We do not claim to have invented a new quorum, a new cryptographic primitive or the general concept of cross-ledger transfer.

The proposed contribution is a specific interstellar payment contract combining single-home authority, local final settlement, destination-bound non-expiring exports, a permanent import-or-reject decision, evidence-dependent recovery, and explicit propagation of monetary trust. The combination is developed here for one-way contact and intervals longer than ordinary monitoring or expiry windows. Its priority and completeness require comparison beyond a limited bibliography. Interstellar terminology alone establishes no novelty.

The architecture deliberately omits a universal mining contest, automatic trust in new domains, guaranteed recovery from destroyed authorities, instantaneous global revocation, arbitrary cross-domain atomic smart contracts, a compulsory speculative token and an unconditional cryptographic lifetime. Adding any of them changes the problem and needs additional mechanisms and assumptions. The monetary argument is about one transfer and its composition under accepted domain histories, not every service that might be built above it.

16. Conclusion

Interstellar payment can be organized around the location of spend authority instead of the latest globally preferred history. A community finalizes its own payments against locally homed funds. An owner paying elsewhere first surrenders local spendability, then sends a certificate bound to one destination and one recipient. The destination's permanent decision permits import or recovery, while lost messages never authorize a second allocation. Once imported, value can circulate locally without a return message to its former home.

This supports a concrete form of autonomy: interruption of distant contact does not itself overturn local settlement. It requires explicit confidence in the participating authority histories, preserved anti-replay state and sustainable local operations. Safety can leave money unavailable when a necessary authority disappears. The appropriate response is to price and disclose that risk, preposition funds where they will be used, and improve the supporting institutions and cryptography without claiming to remove causality.

An open payment fabric built on these rules could allow communities to remain economically connected without depending on one continuously reachable center. Establishing that possibility as a useful system requires exact profiles, independent analysis and real operations. The scientific claim is narrower and testable: under the stated fault and custody assumptions, asynchronous transfer of exclusive spend authority preserves value while allowing final local payments during inter-domain isolation.

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